

Cold weather safety

When exposed to cold, the body loses heat faster than it can produce it. Your job is to recognize warning signs, shelter the person, remove wet gear, and warm them gradually — without causing secondary burns or tissue damage.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW IF...

When extreme cold becomes an emergency

- The person shows signs of **severe hypothermia**: confusion, memory loss, slurred speech, extreme drowsiness, or shivering that stops completely while they remain cold.
- The person is **unresponsive or unconscious** and feels cold to the touch.
- The person is suffering from **severe frostbite** (skin is blue, gray, white, or black, or feels hard/waxy).

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK). Put the phone on speaker and follow dispatcher instructions.

How to treat hypothermia (low body temperature)

- 1 **Get them to a warm, dry shelter.** Protect them from the wind and cold ground.
 - 2 **Remove wet clothing immediately.** Dry wet skin. Dress them in dry, warm clothes and wrap them in warm blankets (covering the head and chest first, leaving the face clear).
 - 3 **Warm the center of the body first.** Use dry blankets, sleeping bags, or skin-to-skin contact. Focus on the chest, neck, head, and groin.
 - 4 **Do NOT use direct high heat** like hot water, fire, heating lamps, or heating pads. Warming someone too fast can cause severe burns, rapid blood pressure drop, or shock.
 - 5 **Give warm, non-alcoholic, sweet drinks** if they are fully conscious, awake, and able to swallow. Never force a sleepy or confused person to drink. Do not give caffeine or alcohol.
 - 6 **If they are unresponsive and not breathing normally,** start hands-only CPR immediately. Keep rewarming them while CPR is ongoing.
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How to treat frostbite (frozen tissue)

PROTECT FROZEN SKIN FROM FURTHER DAMAGE

Frostbite occurs when skin freezes. Never rub or massage frostbitten skin — rubbing snow or friction can tear frozen cells and destroy tissue permanently. Warm the area gradually:

- **Get out of the cold.** Do not attempt to rewarm if there is a risk of refreezing (frozen tissue that refreezes suffers severe, irreversible damage).
- **Do NOT walk on frostbitten feet or toes** unless absolutely necessary to get to safety, as walking causes severe structural damage.
- **Use body heat** to warm the area (for example, tuck frostbitten fingers under the armpit).
- **Immerse the area in warm water** — NOT hot water. The water should be comfortable to touch for unaffected skin (about 99-104°F / 37-40°C). Do not use heating pads, stoves, or fires, as numb skin burns easily without the person feeling it.

Special care for vulnerable populations

- **Infants (<1 year):** Infants lose heat extremely quickly. Never let an infant sleep in a cold room. For infants, warning signs are bright red, cold skin and very low energy. Wrap them securely and seek a warm environment immediately.
- **Older adults:** Older adults may produce less body heat and may have medical conditions or take medicines that make it harder to sense cold or regulate temperature. Check on elderly neighbors regularly during cold snaps.
- **Unhoused individuals:** Cold weather is highly hazardous to people without stable shelter. Coordinate with local outreach teams to distribute dry socks, hand warmers, and sleeping bags.

Sources

- CDC — Prevent hypothermia and frostbite (signs of hypothermia, rewarming center-first, no direct high heat).
- American Red Cross — Cold-related emergencies first aid (gradual warming, avoid friction/rubbing for frostbite, CPR).
- Wilderness Medical Society (WMS) — Practice guidelines for accidental hypothermia and frostbite (field evaluation, risk of refreezing, core warming focus).
- NHS — Hypothermia first-aid guidance (warm drinks, wrap head, check responsiveness).
- NHS — Frostbite rewarming and safety (warm water rewarming, avoid direct high heat, avoid friction).

Guidance reflects standard lay-responder first aid for cold-related injuries. Follow local emergency services and professional medical training.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.